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Sonny Igoe

Drummer Sonny Igoe was born in Jersey City, New Jersey on October 8, 1923. After service in the Marine Corps, he toured with Les Elgart and Ina Ray Hutton, and was a member of Woody Herman's Third Herd. Sonny worked in the New York City recording studios during the 1960s and is now a respected percussion teacher.

Sonny was interviewed at his home in Emerson, New Jersey on July 31, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Emerson, New Jersey. I'm very pleased to be speaking with Sonny Igoe today for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College.

SI: Thank you for that.

MR: It's a real pleasure to be here amongst your memorabilia.

SI: Well I told you it would be a mess.

MR: I see a rather large drumstick back there. Is that special for students who don't quite do their flams?

SI: Well you would think I could really club them with this, wouldn't you? But this is from a store that went out of business in New York called Professional Percussion. And one of the fellas who worked there was taking lessons with me so he brought me — I don't know what happened to the other one, maybe I broke it on somebody.

MR: Well just before we started here you were talking about some of your early gigs with a good friend of Hamilton actually, Bucky Pizzarelli. He's been up to the college a number of times.

SI: Oh he's great for that.

MR: And I like the stories about those four dollar gigs.

SI: Oh, yeah. That's all we made.

MR: If you don't mind just relating some of those, about the wedding?

SI: Oh yeah when we were kids coming up in so-called musically, we were still in high school, and you know there was no rock & roll or Pop music as we know it today. It was all jazz and big bands, dance bands, you know like Vaughn Monroe, Jimmy Dorsey, Tommy Dorsey, Benny Goodman. They were jazz players but they were primarily dance bands. And people danced to the music. And so when we were in high school, he was in Paterson, I was in Ridgewood, our paths didn't cross yet. And I played with a band called Harry Comet. And jokingly we called it Harry Comet and his Meteorites. And when we played a job we made five dollars, and if we played a job on New Year's Eve we might have made twelve for New Year's Eve. Back then that was big money, in 1938, 1939.

Nobody had any money, the depression wasn't even over yet. And that's the way we learned to how to play, by playing all kinds of job. Now I think you were referring to the job about the wedding that came up? Bucky and I were playing an Italian wedding at a place called the Lafayette Friend's Club in East Paterson. And I played there a lot, he played there a lot, sometimes we played together there. And this time we did. And I forget whose band it was. Anyway in those days the weddings were not glamorous like they are today. The caterer was a man who brought in barrels of sandwiches wrapped, and if somebody wanted a ham on rye they'd throw it, or throw me a turkey or a roast beef or whatever, and the booze was just keg beer, and everybody had a marvelous time. Everybody was dancing and having a marvelous time. And on this particular night I can remember still very clearly, we were playing along and all of a sudden these people start coming on the stage from both sides. And they were all Bucky's relatives: his grandfather, his uncles, his cousins. And they all could play guitar or mandolin or something. So we did about a half an hour of Italian wedding stuff [scats]. And they loved it. And then they all disappeared. Nobody got paid. They just showed up and played and left. And so that's the way it was back then.

MR: That's cool.

SI: I think I might have gotten four dollars on that job.

MR: Yeah. And what else would have been on your song list? Ellington stuff?

SI: Oh well, sure. You played, back then you couldn't play in a band, a horn, unless you were just jamming in a club, without being able to read music. Because they passed out what they called stock arrangements. Now they had these stock arrangements where you'd get all the Glenn Miller stuff, like "In the Mood," "Little Brown Jug" and all that; the Tommy Dorsey stuff; Benny Goodman stuff. And you played all that because that was the popular stuff on the radio and that's what people expected to dance to when you played it. [scats] And everybody gets up and dances.

MR: Would there have been a singer?

SI: Oh yes. Usually a guy but sometimes a girl. And it was set up, it was like we were supposed to be kind of like an imitation name band. Low budget name band. Really, I had so much fun doing that. And I thought we were good. But I was so naïve I thought everybody thought I was a good drummer when I was kid but apparently that was not the case.

MR: Really?

SI: Oh sure. I had a lot of stuff that Gene Krupa played, memorized, you know and that kind of stuff. He was my idol when I was a kid. So I would play some of that stuff, I said well everybody would love this. And some guys said, "you know everybody doesn't play like Gene Krupa, Sonny."

MR: Uh huh. Didn't you win a Gene Krupa contest?

SI: Yes I did. That's what I'm sort of leading up to. I was very — well I always say I was lucky because I was only 16, and Gene had — the publicity got out — excuse me is this legal? The publicity came out that Gene was going to have a drum contest for amateur drummers, kids. And so he called up and talked to the people at the Meadowbrook or whoever, and I called up — my mother called up I guess — no it was my grandmother called up. Because she lived in East Orange and she heard about, she called up and told them about me. So they took our number and they called us and we went that afternoon. And there were about 40 drummers. And we were set up on the dance floor at the Meadowbrook. And Gene didn't know how to handle it quite, because it's the first time he had did that and he didn't expect that many guys to begin with. And the majority of the fellas came with these very glamorous sets just like Gene's. I had a junky, terrible, as a matter of fact half of it was in this picture here where you really can't see much but look how old fashioned that is. That would really hold back, with the temple block and the tom toms that you tune, that was called Chinese tom toms. And I was about that age.

MR: Did you have a hi hat?

SI: Yes, right over here. See this great big thing here?

MR: Yeah.

SI: That's what they called a hi hat in those days. Those cymbals were awful. They were just terrible. But anyway that's what my set looked like.

MR: I'm so glad — look at — you have the chair.

SI: Yes and I put a pillow so I could sit high enough.

MR: That's great.

SI: I didn't have any stool or something. Anyway but that's what my set was the pits. Everybody else had great drums. So anyway I had had the good fortune to have met a fellow named Joe Mooney who was a marvelous musician from Paterson. He was blind. He played accordion like you never heard. It sounded like a brass section when he played the accordion. It was just great. He was a marvelous arranger. And my mother had a Hammond organ. My mother was a fine pianist. She had a Hammond organ when they first came out. And they asked her if it would be all right if they used her organ and our house for a demonstration, for appointments. And I don't know what kind of — if she got paid for that or anything like that or if they gave her the organ probably or something like that. Anyway Joe Mooney heard about it and came up and he played the organ and you couldn't get my mother away from him, because when he played the organ he was unbelievable. So he brought some guys up and they let me jam with them. And they really taught me how to play on those jam sessions. It was great. I was playing with Bobby Domenick, Bucky Pizzarelli's older uncle, so next time you see Bucky ask him

about Bobby Domenick. He sat right next to me and said, "listen" [scats] and I was like — I tell you I played with those guys, it was marvelous. And they taught me how to keep time. They really were great with me. They were so tolerant. I say I thought everybody loved me, but I don't know how I sounded, really. But they were tolerant. They asked me to play all the time. So then we go to this contest. So Gene finally decides, I asked him to sign my snare drum for luck, you know you get it autographed. And I had that head for years, I don't know what happened to it but I had it for years. Anyway he was so gracious. And I was number three. So they finally decided, "here's the way we'll do this. We'll get a small group from the band, like four or five guys, and play two choruses of the tune with each drummer and the first chorus will be together and then the second chorus will be the drum solo, and then the last eight bars out." Okay. Well I knew what he was talking about because I'd been playing with these guys.

MR: Ah, important.

SI: And they'd say, "Sonny you play the bridge," or, "you play the last eight." I knew where it was because I could hear it. So anyway it comes to be my turn, I was number three, he says, "okay now Sonny, what would you like to play?" I was struck dumb. Absolutely dumb. And I said, "gee, I don't know." He said, "how about 'China Boy?'" Well I said fine because I'd been playing "China Boy" for years with his records when he was with Benny Goodman. So I knew the tune backwards and forwards. So he says "you play four bars then they'll come in." I said, "okay." So I [scats] whatever I did, and they came in, and I played through and then I played the solo, and the last eight bars out. I was one of the only ones who knew what to do. The rest of the kids just played solos all the time, they didn't know how to play in the band.

MR: You could play some time.

SI: Keeping time, and I knew when it was time for me to play and when the last eight bars came, they'd go back and they'd all come in again and they all did. And Gene said, "boy they don't fool around with it up in Ridgewood." So anyway I figured that by the time they decided who was going to win, they'd forgotten about me, I was number three.

MR: Three out of 40.

SI: About 40. So anyway Gene brought about six or eight of us up on the stage and I was thrilled to be standing on the bandstand at the Meadowbrook. I had worked there many times after that, but I was like this was big time stuff. So anyway Gene goes down the line, put his hands over this guy and over this guy and over this guy. And I was the last one he came to. And I got the biggest hand. I don't see how anybody remembered me. And some guys had their own cheering sections there. But still and all, my mother said, "I didn't think you were going to beat that kid that has all his friends." And so anyway sure enough, I won the contest and a lot of people heard about it and that sort of thing.

And I was a lucky kid. I was lucky I met those guys, and had that opportunity to play with them at an early age, and I was a heavy listener and a heavy practicer. And I had some luck. And that was a lucky day for me because I was a little on the sick side, I had a sore throat and a little temperature. They said, "maybe you better stay home." I said, "no I'm not going to stay home, take me down there." Because I couldn't drive. So that was it. And Gene kind of adopted me as his protégé. I'd go see him play at different places and he'd "come on up here." And he'd be signing autographs. And people went, "who's that kid? Who's that kid?" And he said, "this is my protégé. Sonny Igoe, and he's a protégé of mine." Because he sent me to a teacher in New York after I won the contest. My mother said to him, "do you think he can do anything with the drums?" He said, "are you kidding? He can't miss." So he said, "I have a teacher for you to go to in New York." She said, "New York?" So she took me to the first lesson. And then I went by myself. At that time from Ridgewood to New York the bus fare was 35 cents. So I used to go for my lessons in New York and come home on my own. I was 16. And it was a marvelous time for me. But then I was into the mix in New York already. Competition with other students who were coming in to this guy and they were hanging around and talking and this, that and the other thing.

MR: Making connections.

SI: A very famous drummer, he and I became very good friends over the years, Ed Shaughnessy. And he took lessons with the same guy. And we were sort of like, as we got older, friendly rivals. And I went in the service and Ed was too young. And when I came out he was still there. And so we took up our friendship again. And we were helpful to each other in our careers. And I recommended him for jobs and he recommended me. Because you can't do anything alone in this business. You've got to have help. I had a lot of help when I was a kid, you know people telling me things, giving me advice. And you can't do anything without people recommending you. Your reputation precedes you, and when you've done a certain amount of things with a certain amount of people, then you don't audition anymore. The thing with me was when I got the gig with Benny Goodman and played with him for a year, after that I didn't have to audition for anybody. They'd just call and say are you available. Because they figured if I could play with Benny, that's a good test.

MR: That's great.

SI: So that was after the war though. The other things were pre-war.

MR: What did your parents do for a living? Your father?

SI: My father was in a business he hated. He was the manager of a finance company in Jersey City. It was a family business. His father and I think his mother too, well my grandmother, I don't know if she was born in Jersey City. But he came over from Ireland

as a young man, his father, my grandfather, came over from Ireland. And he started this business. He was a smart guy I guess. He started this business, he had license number three in New Jersey for all the finance companies in New Jersey. He had number three. So my father, when he died my father had to run the business. And he hated that. He didn't like it. And so anyway that's what he did. My mother, like all mothers back then, she was home all the time. But she was a very fine classical pianist. We had a full-sized concert grand in our living room. And boy, she used to have concerts there and they'd bring people out from New York who were supposed to be good and all that kind of stuff. They had like a music club. And they'd bring people out from New York. And I would be above the piano in my bedroom, and I could hear some of these people and think boy, it sounds like he's clubbing it. And then my mother would play and her touch was so much better than a lot of them. Here she was a housewife, but she was a practicing fool. I tell people this story because talk about practice — she had small hands, she couldn't reach that far. So she was constantly doing these kind of exercises to get loose. And she had this system. She'd put a hundred matches here. Okay? On this side of the piano. And she's trying a certain thing from a certain concerto. Down and up. Okay put one match over there. [scats] Another match over there. A hundred on this side, then a hundred from that side up on another portion the way she — that may be where I got my practice ethic. Because in high school I used to practice four to six hours a day myself all the time. I wasn't scholastically great. Because I had blinders on. Everything was drums and everybody knew it was going to be drums.

MR: So there wasn't much doubt what you were going to be doing for a living.

SI: Oh absolutely, absolutely. My father — as long as Gene Krupa was in charge so to speak, of sending me to a teacher and saying that he thought I had the stuff that I could make a go of it, you know.

MR: And did your parents like the swing music of the day too?

SI: Oh absolutely. My mother was nuts about it. And she would say, "see the way he's playing?" She said, "he's so smooth and he smiles, but he's got another thing, that umph." She'd call it umph. He's got a lot of umph.

MR: That's neat. It's funny nowadays, I think for a while there's been a separation between children and adults as far as their musical tastes.

SI: Well probably. There was certainly a big disparaging thing in this house. I have a magnificent — I treated myself when I finally started making a little decent money — I treated myself to a marvelous stereo system for upstairs, all McIntosh, and big JBL studio monitor speakers, and oh what a system. It's still up there. It's never been played above 4 it's so powerful. So anyway my kids started, the girls, both of my girls, they're about six years apart, but it was The Beatles, you know when The Beatles started. And I'd say,

"how can you listen to that?" I said, "that's terrible. It's like nursery rhymes set to music. You could sing 'Three Blind Mice' like that. Terrible music." Well naturally The Beatles were The Beatles and that's all — the kids are walking up and down the street singing The Beatles songs. Nobody's singing Benny Goodman licks anymore. But anyway I should have realized the handwriting on the wall at that time back then but I was stubborn. And I said, "you can't play that stuff on my machine. Play it up in the bedroom on your stuff. You can't do it on my stuff." So they had to play theirs upstairs.

MR: Did they have any sense that you used to be in the middle of what was swinging popular music? Did they realize that?

SI: Oh I think so, especially in the days when I got to stay home. See I spent an awful lot of time on the road. And so I started to stay home. I had a good Dixieland career down in Nick's in Greenwich Village when it was the place for Dixieland. And actually that was the best steady jazz job in New York at the time. And so I played there for three or four years. And that was after I had finished with Charlie Ventura's group. And I played there for about three or four years. So finally, it's not like okay you have a job for six months and then you're off for three or something like that. This was like a year round thing, six nights a week and a Sunday afternoon.

MR: Wow. Every single day.

SI: Oh yeah. We worked from — the hours were 9:30 to 4 on weeknights, 9 to 3 on Saturday night and Sunday afternoon from 5 to 9 and then 10 to 3. That was the week. And it was marvelous. All great musicians, and it really was a fun job.

MR: Can I ask how much you were making for those kind of hours?

SI: Yes we were making — I started at $150 a week. Three days later after I had started I got a telegram from the leader saying, "I'm giving you a $30 raise." So I went to $180. But that was unheard of in a jazz club in New York. The guys up the street — I won't mention names — but the guys up the street at the Village Vanguard were putting in — they didn't have a Sunday afternoon matinee but they had six nights like we did, the same hours until 4 in the morning that — New York was going until 4 in the morning in those days because you could walk the streets, there was no problems. And I'd meet some of these guys. There was a diner midway between us so we'd all have a cup of coffee and meet some of these guys, some guys you know. "Hey what are you doing?" "Well I'm up at the Vanguard, man. What are you doing?" "I'm playing at Nick's." "Oh, hey what are you making down there?" I said, "I'm making $180." He says, "what? $180?" I says, "well what are you guys making up there?" He says, "$80." 80 bucks a week.

MR: This is mid-50's right?

SI: This is going to the end of — yes. It was from '54 on. '54 on. There was no scale for those kind of clubs. Because the union wasn't in any of those things. And so Nick's

always had a reputation for paying their guys well. But you worked hard. And it was a very pleasant atmosphere, no problem. And you know I can remember when I started with Benny Goodman's band, now we're talking 19 — what would that be, — 19—

MR: '48?

SI: '48 and '49. That's right. I was going to say '47. No '48. And there's a long story concerned with this, and it's the thing I told you before. You can't do anything alone. Somebody's got to help you. So I had come off the road playing with three what we would call back in those days B bands. They weren't like the Benny Goodman or that sort of thing. They were like a guy named Tommy Reed who had a band that was made up of all ex-servicemen. I went out to San Francisco to play with him. And then I was with Les Elgart's band at the Meadowbrook, and then I was with a lady bandleader named Ina Ray Hutton, I don't know if you ever heard of her. She used to have a girl band but now she had a guy band. And then all those jobs fizzled out and then from one to another you get a call, "would you like to audition for Ina Ray Hutton?" Sure, because I don't have a gig. And I wasn't married yet or anything like that. So those bands, Tommy Reed, Ina Ray Hutton and Les Elgart were 90 dollar bands. That's a week on the road with hotels and meals you had to pay your own.

MR: You had to pay your own.

SI: Yeah. And you know you wonder, 90 bucks, how did I ever do that? So okay now a long thing goes on, and I know that Benny Goodman is rehearsing a new band. And I had also heard that he was getting a drummer every day. He didn't like anybody or blah-blah-blah, whatever it was. So guys were telling me — there used to be a hangout in New York called Charlie's Tavern, where everybody used to go because beers were a nickel and we could hang around there, drink beer, lie, you know tell a lot of lies. So anyway, this guy goes, "hey Sonny, you ought to go up to Benny's rehearsal" he said, "he's having trouble finding somebody he likes." I said, "he'll probably hire Shelly Manne or somebody like that." But I thought about it and thought about it and it came to me that I had the acquaintance of a man who was an insurance executive who was a friend of Benny Goodman's. And he used to hang around Charlie's Tavern. He loved musicians. He loved to talk to us and all that kind of stuff. So I asked him. His name was Eddie Furst. And I said, "Ed, do you think you could introduce me to Benny Goodman so I could audition?" He said, "sure, Sonny, I can fix that up." He said, "I don't know why I didn't think of that." He said, "good, I'll call him." So he called me the next day and said, "we're going up Thursday at 11:00" or whatever the heck it was. Right? So he takes me and we go up there and he's rehearsing at MCA in New York, wherever their offices were. They had an auditorium. And they were rehearsing in there. And I had a very good ear. I memorize very quickly, luckily. It's another lucky thing, you can't teach it. So anyway we go up

there and the band is playing and they were rehearsing this one tune three or four times through, five or six times through, whatever. And I'm listening to it. And I'm getting that down pretty good already, and I'll see if I can play that tune. But you never know, you might have to go up there and sight read. So anyway I could read passably. I was not to what I developed into. But anyway they take a break. And so Benny said, "Eddie, how are you?" And he comes over and shakes his hand. And he says, "this is the young man I was telling you about, Benny." And he said, "oh, nice to meet you Sonny," he said, "why don't you play the next set," he says. He says, "we'll take a ten minute break" or something like that and he says, "you play the next set." The drummer was from Philadelphia and he was very inexperienced. Really nice kid. Scared to death. Not that I wasn't nervous, Benny Goodman, my God, this was a whole new strata for me. And this kid, I don't think he played with anybody. But anyway he was so accommodating. I said, "do you mind if I use your drums to play the next set" or something. He said, "oh please" he said, "please." And we introduced ourselves and all that kind of stuff. A very nice guy. But he wasn't ready for that. I wasn't sure I was, you know because my heart was going like this [taps], but I knew several guys in the band from Charlie's Tavern and around town. I hadn't worked with any of the guys yet. So anyway okay I sit in. And they play that tune that I had sat through five or six times. And I had the part up, like I pretend I'm reading it. And so anyway I didn't have to really read much of it, it wasn't that complex, but there was a couple of starts and stops and a few things in it. And I went through it [claps] just like that. So Benny looked up like this. And he said, "stay up there, Pops."

MR: Pops. He called you Pops already.

SI: Everybody. Yeah he called everybody Pops. So anyway he says, "stay up there, Pops." So anyway I stayed up there and I played a few more tunes I got lucky enough to get through. And then he said, "okay, everybody's through, we'll play with the quartet." So he said, "stay up there, Pops." So Buddy Greco was the piano player and Benny, and bass player was a fellow named Clyde Lombardi. And so we played with just a small group for about an hour. And so then he packed up and walked out. He didn't say a word to me, that was it. So oh he did say, "come back tomorrow, bring your own drums in." Something like that. I go, "yeah." So I go back tomorrow, and then I played the whole rehearsal. And then again at the end he goes through the small band, because he loved playing with the small group too. And we played that. And so it's going on three weeks now. And I get a call from another clarinet player, a guy named Jerry Wald. You ever hear that name? Anyway he was going into the Paramount Theater. And he asked me if I'd be interested in doing the Paramount with him. And I said, "I'm rehearsing with Benny." He said, "well did he hire you yet?" I said, "I've been doing it for three weeks he hasn't said a word." He says, "well listen, I can give you another couple of days and then

I'll have to get somebody else. He says, "but the job is yours if you want it." And I said, "okay, thank you, very nice of you." Blah-blah-blah. So anyway the next day I'm at rehearsal with Benny, right? Now Benny used to walk around as I call tooteling all the time. He'd go [scats]. And he comes up to me and gives me a nudge, and he's tooteling. Like this. He says, "get your suit yet, Pops?" And I said, "what do you mean get my suit yet?" He says, "you know, your uniform." Because the band was going to Sacks Fifth Avenue for tuxedo coats. So I said no. He said, "why don't you get your uniform?" I said, "nobody told me I was hired." He said, "nobody told you you were hired? You were hired the first day." He said, "nobody said anything?" I said, "no, you never said anything." He said, "he's supposed to — where's what's his—" the manager. "Come up here. Talk to him." So okay. Now the big decision of my life comes up, right? So the guy says, "oh Sonny it was my fault," he says, "I apologize." He said "Benny'd love to—" blah-blah-blah-blah. So he says, "you got the job" and he said, "you've got to get your uniform." And he said, "now how much money do you want?" Nobody ever asked me that before. Right? I can remember Gene Krupa saying, "if you ever play with Benny Goodman he respects you if you ask for a lot of money." But I didn't feel as though I was that secure you know. But that ran through my mind. So I had come from these, like I said, these 90 dollar bands. Never made more than 90 bucks a week. So I kind haltingly said, "how about $125?" He says, "well I think we can make that." And I could almost hear him going chuckle-chuckle-chuckle. So anyway that's the way that went. I was the lowest paid guy in the band. I would have swept out the bus, I don't care. But I spent a year with Benny until he broke up the band. He went to the Philippines for a month with the quartet. But I spent a year with him. And I really felt as though I learned a lot, I came a long way experience-wise and how to really play in a band and gee to have somebody as good as him. He never once, he used to be from a lot of guys they said he used to be very bad on a lot of people. But he never once said anything to me about my playing. He never said you're playing too loud, you're rushing, you're dragging, you're doing this, you're doing that. Never said anything. Just fine. Not that we were buddy-buddy, but he never said anything about my playing so I figured I was alright. So that put me over the top from the standpoint of having to audition with other bands if I went with — so I went from Benny Goodman to Woody Herman, you know and that was my next step. But it was funny in those days the way everybody said, "you've got to watch, boy you're working for Benny — did you get 'the ray' yet?" Talk about the ray. I have a story about "the ray" if you're interested.

MR: I am.

SI: Have you heard about that?

MR: I've heard about it but please go ahead.

SI: The thing is that he would, he even said to us one night at the Palladium in Hollywood he says, "you've heard a lot about the ray" he says, "I'm not really mad at anybody." He said, "sometimes I daydream and my mind wanders and I just happen to be looking in somebody's direction. I'm not trying to stare them down or anything like that" you know blah-blah-blah. So okay. So now we're in Canada doing a whole string of one-nighters in the hockey rinks. They used to put the boards down on the ice so people could dance, and then they would build this tremendous movie set for the band. They'd have the saxes down here and each section up. The drums were like up there. Way up at the top. Unbelievable. You couldn't hear anything. You couldn't hear the band you were so far away. And so and Benny's down there. So we play the first set and Benny, he's looking around and puzzled. And he looks up at me, and I had another small set down in front for the small group. So he looked up at me and he goes — you know what that means. You come on down here and play down here. Okay? So not a word was said. So I pick up my sticks and brushes and go down to the other set. And I played a set down there and I'm in seventh heaven because the whole band is right here in my ear. Oh what a feeling that is. That's why when people play music today all they do is turn up the bass. You hear bluh-bluh-bluh. It doesn't sound like music. But when you have the brilliance of the brass and the saxophones right, oh man, it's hi-fi, the original hi-fi. So anyway okay we take a break. Now we're coming back up and I'm down front now and I got a little closer and got myself comfortable and I have my music stand here in case I need some charts. And Benny's right over my music stand like this, eye level. I'm kind of kitty corner to him. If I look there, there he is. Now he had the habit of having his clarinet under his arm like this, holding it this way. So he was in that pose looking right at me. And I could hear some murmurs in the background, guys in the sax section saying, "uh-oh, look's like it's Sonny's turn in the barrel tonight" or something like that and all these kinds of things. So he's just looking at me over the top of my stand. Just staring at me. And geez I'd had enough. So I stood up, and this is true, I stood up and I went like this in front of his eyes. He never budged. And the band, everybody's having hysterics. They thought I'd get canned right then. He said, "sit down kid, what are you doing?" He never knew I did it. So he says, "okay let's go." And we went on to the next number. That story got around town in New York even. "Geez I heard what you did to Benny." It was funny. He never even acknowledged it. But I did see him ride some guys sometimes and I felt sorry for them. I think it was one of those things that every once in a while if he got in that mood if he knew he could ride you he'd ride you. There are people like that. If they know they can take advantage of you they'll do it, or try.

MR: Well Ed Shaughnessy told us about just — he got on his case once and he just went real weird on him and kind of one upmanshipped him.

SI: Oh yeah?

MR: And he left him alone after that.

SI: Oh yeah, sure, sure. Well that must have been after my episode.

MR: Yeah it was after.

SI: Because Ed and I didn't see each other for a long time. But I knew that he had played with Benny. But I didn't know that he had an episode so to speak.

MR: When you were touring with Benny, or later Woody Herman, were you playing for like integrated audiences?

SI: Oh yeah. But the problem was that when you got down south they couldn't mingle. You know they'd have, of course then everybody was colored.

MR: The term.

SI: Yeah. The term was colored. So the coloreds would be in the balcony. They could listen but they couldn't come down and dance. I don't know if they danced in the hallways or anything like that because we couldn't see. But they were definitely segregated. And we didn't have any Black guys in the band with Benny in the year — I was on tour with Stan Kenton in 1954 when I was with Charlie Ventura. And there was two buses there were so many people on this tour. It was a great — he called it the Festival of Modern American Jazz. And it was Stan Kenton's band and Shorty Rogers and Shelly Manne, Art Tatum Trio, June Christy, Lennie — oh I can't think of his name

MR: Niehaus?

SI: Niehaus was in the band. But anyway a whole bunch of people. It was almost a three hour show. And Charlie Ventura's group with Mary Ann McCall singing. And so we played down south. We went on a 68 night tour with no breaks. No nights off. And two buses. And I was in the bus with Art Tatum and his trio guys and a couple of other fellas, a band boy and a couple of others. There weren't as many people on our bus. Most of the band was in the other bus. And my window mate, my bus mate was Jimmy Guiffre. The guy who wrote "Four Brothers" for Woody. And he and I were yacking all the time. He was a marvelous guy, a terrific guy. You look at Jimmy and you think he doesn't have a personality because he's so quiet and his demeanor is so professorial as we would say. But he's got a wacky sense of humor and it was a pleasure to talk with him all this time. So we would get down south but Art and his guys couldn't — we stopped for a rest stop thinking we'd get off the bus and we'd stop to eat and they couldn't get off the bus. I used to bring them coffee, sodas and stuff, we all did. Everybody catered to those guys. Because they didn't want to get involved in anything because it was still like that that down there. Because I remember when I was in the Marines it was terrible, during the war, in the southern cities it was terrible.

MR: Even, they didn't even respect that they were servicemen.

SI: Nah, nah, nah. Terrible. As a matter of fact we used to get sometimes in trouble. There would be two drinking fountains. Whites only. Colored only. We'd always drink out of the colored. People would say, "get out of there you white trash" and that kind of stuff.

MR: Is that right?

SI: Oh that was the 40s. You can't imagine that today, actually. Terrible. But they didn't have that kind of, they couldn't stay in the same hotels, they had to have them in the section of town where they could stay. Some of them stayed like in boarding houses. So but there was no extended stays on that tour. So once in a while we'd stay over because the next jump wasn't that far. But that was the way it was back then. And even though like Gene had Roy Eldridge in his band for years, that was before that time in the late 30s. It must have been terrible for those guys back then. Where are we?

MR: You eventually got — did you get tired of the road?

SI: Oh I got tired of the road, yeah. I was with Ina Ray Hutton's band and we had played a big nightclub in New York called the Latin Quarter when there was a Latin Quarter. It was like the Copacabana, with showgirls and all this kind of stuff — with Ina Ray Hutton's band. Then we went out to Covington, Kentucky. Now Covington, Kentucky is just across the river from Cincinnati. And they had a miniature Las Vegas there, three casinos I think. Not like a casino today, but you could gamble, roulette wheel and blackjack and all that stuff. So we were at a place called the Lookout House with Ina Ray Hutton's band. And they had a big show built around Ina Ray Hutton that they had made from the — modeled on the Latin Quarter thing, like a package. Then they had eight dancing girls. I had to go to Covington, Kentucky to meet a girl from Brooklyn. That's how my wife and I met.

MR: Is that right?

SI: Yeah. She was in the chorus line.

MR: No kidding.

SI: Yeah. And she says, "you used to try to louse us up every night with that two bar solo you played, we'd all get out of step." So I think you mentioned being on the road. So I got married, it must have been a year or two after that. We got married. And I was with Woody's band. And he gave me two weeks off to get married. So we came home and we got — nothing special, no big wedding or anything like that.

MR: You weren't throwing sandwiches, were you?

SI: No, no, nothing like that. I think we went to the local tavern. So anyway — oh I remember our wedding night my wife and I saw two Charles Dickens movies.

MR: Really.

SI: Yeah. Because the next day we were getting in the car and driving out to Nebraska on the way to meet the band, in Fall City, Nebraska I think it was. So anyway to make a long

story short, my wife got pregnant early and had to leave me on the road, she had to go home. So my father and mother found a place in North Bergen, they were building new apartments in those days and so we got an apartment over there. And when she had the baby I wanted to get time off because of the baby. And Woody wouldn't give it to me. So I said well I'm going to have to leave the band. He says okay. So I left the band. And the last night I had with the band we were playing at Buckeye Lake, Ohio, it's a big place where bands played. And across the lake was Tommy Dorsey's band playing the same night. Now they got through an hour before we did so they came around to us in their bus to hear our band. So we were playing our last couple of sets and I knew Louie Bellson, he was with the band. And Louie came in. And so anyway we were playing our last couple of sets and Tommy's talking to Woody and Woody told him that I was leaving. He says, "he's leaving the band?" And he says, "how come?" He says, "well his wife's going to have a baby." "Oh where does he live?" "New Jersey." He says, "well we're going to be playing in New Jersey for a month." So Louie Bellson was leaving. He didn't have anybody set. So he had his manager come up and talk to me about joining his band. So I left Woody one day and joined Tommy Dorsey two days later at the Syracuse Hotel up in Syracuse. And so I was supposed to play at a place called the Rustic Cabin for a month with the band. Because we lived just a few miles down the pike so to speak, down the Palisades. So anyway he gets on the bandstand and says, "it's great to have a" blah-blah-blah-blah. So anyway the last night we had a jam session and it was very good and a lot of fun and all that kind of stuff, on the stand in the hotel. And so we packed up all this stuff and all the stuff is going on a truck or a bus or however they got it around in those days, I forgot. So anyway I'm in bed about four and the phone rings. And I pick up the phone and he said, "Sonny?" I says, "yes." He says, "this is so-and-so" I forget the guy's name, the manager of the band. He said, "Tommy just told me to fire you." And I said, "what?" I said, "I thought he said he liked the way I played." He said, "I don't know" he said, "get rid of that guy." So I said, "okay." But I said, "I want the money for the Rustic Cabin or I'm going to take it to the union." So he said, "I'll tell you what I'll do. I'll give you" — I forget what I was going to get for the — it was pretty good money for me at that time, I think it was about 300 bucks a week, but he said, "I'll tell you what I'll do, I'll give you 400 dollars cash tomorrow and we'll forget about it." Because then he was going to put the rest in his pocket and he was going to tell Tommy he had to pay me and he could put the rest of that money in his pocket. He was famous for that. So that's why some of those band leaders died broke you know, their managers were doing that to them. So anyway as it happened I went to the union and said this is what they said, this is what has happened and they said okay, we'll back you. And I said, "but they want me to come there every night and just hang around for a while." He said, "well how far is it from your

home?" I said, "six or eight miles." He said, "well why don't you keep it quiet, just go up there and hang around for an hour and leave." And he said, "we'll back you up and we'll get your money." And so they did, they got the money, they got the full 1200 bucks; 1200 bucks was 1200 bucks. And so they got the money for me. And so the first night I went up there Tommy was busy resetting the band, he didn't like the way they had set it up. So my drums were on the corner. They had unloaded them. So I went over to get the drums and I said, "hey Tommy, I thought you said you liked the way I played." And he had a very raspy kind of voice. He said, "listen to me, kid, I don't want anybody in my band who I think is putting me on." He said, "all you young guys think you play different from somebody else." I said, "well I don't think I'm any different but I thought you said you liked it." He said, "nah I don't want anybody in my band who I think is putting me on." So then he says, "did you ever hear of Ray Wetzel?" I said, "sure, the great trumpet player." He said, "he was on this band four times before I let him stay." I said, "do me a favor, don't call me four times." But he called me twice.

MR: Is that right?

SI: He called me twice after that incident. So anyway I never worked with him again but that was it, I took my drums and went home. But that's another little story over a couple of years.

MR: These guys had their distinct personalities, didn't they?

SI: Oh yeah. He and his brother used to have fist fights. Imagine that? Over music? It doesn't make any sense to me. But unfortunately they died before their time. Both those guys. Tommy and Jimmy died young. They died in their early 50s or whatever it was. The bands were dying but they shouldn't have gone that soon. But I guess you can't drink all that booze and not have something—

MR: Well that's the other — I was going to ask about the lifestyle of being a musician at that time.

SI: Well there were some things, if you let certain things get a hold of you, you could have a hard time. I was always a Boy Scout. I could have more fun with the guys — they were smoking a joint or something like that they'd say, "come on, Sonny, you never tried it." I said, "all right I'll try it." So I tried it. Nothing happened. I said, "I can have more fun on a bottle of beer. I don't need that." And I didn't smoke anyway. And so anyway I never got involved with that. And a lot of the fellas got involved with that pretty heavily and then they went into some other things pretty heavily, like heroin, cocaine and stuff like that. And several guys actually, lives ruined completely with that stuff, because they could never kick it. And I won't mention any names, but some very good friends of mine, guys I admired as players, got screwed up badly with that stuff, really bad.

MR: And those kind of guys would have trouble entering the studio world in New York that went to.

SI: Oh yeah, but some of them did. I knew guys in that line of work, like the T.V. business, there was a lot of tension there because you're playing live all the time until tape came in. I knew guys who would belt 'em down all day long and they'd come in bleary eyed but they could sit down and they could read that music and play that music like they were just out of a spring day or something like that. And as soon as it was over they'd go blahhhhh, like that. But they'd just get up for the show and then down. There's one guy, we used to call them junkies when they were shooting. And there was one fellow in one of the bands I played with was a junkie and he was a great saxophone player. And he'd get on the stand and perk right up. And he'd come off the stand and he'd be like this. Intermissions he'd be like — could hardly talk. Get on the stand, play like there was no tomorrow. And there were very few like that. Most guys if they started to nod out they nodded out no matter where they were. You couldn't even wake them up. But there was — are you ready for another story?

MR: Yeah.

SI: So are you ready for another story?

MR: Yeah.

SI: We were on one nighters with Woody Herman's band and when I joined Woody Herman's band in 1950 he was fighting big debts, you know IRS and GMAC, his booking agency, I think he was in to them for about $90,000 or something like that. And he owed over a hundred thousand to the IRS, that's from the manager who screwed him up. And he had this guy Abe Turchin as manager, who got him out of debt and then he screwed him up. He died broke because of him. But anyway we were on the bus and this dear friend of mine, marvelous trumpet player — I won't mention his name — could play anything on the trumpet, played high screeching, beautiful soft ballads, fast bebop, any style, Dixieland, swing, bebop, anything. He was just marvelous. World class. And he was a junkie. And when they would run out of junk they'd drink whiskey like it was coming out of a water faucet, to try to help get over it. Well finally we were in an un-air conditioned bus, we were down in Kentucky or South Carolina, someplace, I don't know, Georgia, in that kind of country. All rural, all hot. And we each had a double seat because there was a lot of seats on the bus and there was 15 guys or whatever. So right across from me is this guy who is a dear friend of mine. And I'm finally falling asleep and I said, "go to sleep, go to sleep." I almost said his name but I don't want to say his name. So anyway I'm falling asleep [sniffs]. I smell burning flesh, okay? And I look over and here's this guy, he had a cigarette with his hand — he was unconscious practically. He has a cigarette like here and it had burned down between his two fingers and was burning

his flesh and smoking. It was actually smoking. So I go like this across the aisle, knock it off, naturally wake him up. And he started in on me like — I can't mention the words he used and how dumb I was and what's the idea and blah-blah-blah. And I tried to explain to him. The next day he saw it, it didn't bother him at all. He played like it never happened. He played like it never happened. But that's how, unfortunately, some of those guys ruined their lives with that stuff. I was glad I was a square. It was good enough for me.

MR: Yeah. Stick with being a Boy Scout. Well tell me a little about making a living in the studio scene in New York.

SI: Well that was one of the happiest times in my life because I was always home and saw my children, and saw my children grow up. Because I missed so much of my first daughter when I was with Woody. He gave me time to go home for the baby and I had to quit to get the time. And so he had another two or three drummers. I was out of the band for ten weeks. And so our baby was now close to ten weeks old, okay? And I get a call, I thought that I already played with Woody Herman, I already played with Benny Goodman successfully, I should be able to make it in the New York recording scene. I'd just hang around and meet guys and get work. Failure. Complete failure. I worked one job in ten weeks. It paid twelve dollars. And on that job we had two bands. It was at a jazz club in New York called the Downbeat. And it was on 54th Street just off Eighth Avenue. And the first band was Charlie Parker, Max Roach, the bass player was Mingus, Charlie Mingus, and I forget who the piano player was. And we had two trombone players, Kai Winding and Bill Harris from my Woody Herman days, and the rhythm section, myself and Percy Heath was the bass player and I forget who the piano player was in it. Anyway we played, this was my first job in ten weeks. We played alternating sets from nine to four in the morning. That's what we used to play, three or four, I forget which. But anyway, we all made the same: Charlie Parker, everybody. Twelve bucks. We all make twelve bucks. That was it. That was the only job I had. So I get a call from Woody's manager and he says, "hey Sonny, Woody's not that happy with anybody since you left," he said, "would you consider coming back with the band?" And I said, "sure," I said, "can I get a little bit more money?" He says, "yeah I think so," he says, "how much more?" So now I'm thinking $125, right? So I said, "well how about $150 clear?" So he'd pay my taxes. He said, "yeah, we'll do that." But he didn't do it.

MR: He didn't pay your taxes?

SI: But he gave me $150 clear but he didn't pay any taxes. So anyway somehow or other he got away with it. But anyway I left home, right? The baby is now ten weeks old. So I'm getting the vast estate in order. I had rent was about 95 bucks and I had a 90 dollar a month car payment and I had a small insurance policy I was paying off. And so I did the

checkbook and I said, "okay hon, I'm leaving you with $119," which is our entire estate. So she says, "that's fine." Because we didn't worry about money back then. You know we were young, in love and a new baby and the hell with it. So anyway I went back with the band. I had to go to Pittsburgh. And I got off at Pittsburgh for the first job and I knew the hotel I was going to so there was a call waiting for me, and it was my wife saying, "are you there yet?" And I said, "well of course I'm here, what's up?" She said, "well you made a terrible mistake, I had to call to tell you this." And I said, "what do you mean I made a terrible mistake?" She said, "you didn't leave me with $119, you left with $1.19." And I said, "oh my God I'll have to borrow some money from the manager and send you some money." So I borrowed a hundred bucks and wired it to her. And that was the way that second career with Woody Herman started. In debt.

MR: You had nowhere to go but up I guess.

SI: Oh absolutely. But people always think about you you did this, you did that and you played with this band or you played with that band. It's not like today. Like if you play with Bruce Springsteen, you play with him for life. Those guys never change jobs. We were jumping all over the place all the time. Those guys stay in the same jobs all their lives you know. Why would you leave a job that pays you four thousand million a year?

MR: It literally was musical chairs, wasn't it.

SI: Oh yeah, sure. I knew guys, great musicians, who would play with the band for two or three months, as soon as they learned the book they wanted to play with another band and learn another book. You know they got tired of playing the same music. You know essentially, you know everyone said oh you're playing with Woody Herman, you're playing with Benny Goodman. Sure it's marvelous, the degree of musicianship is so much higher than the B bands, that sort of thing. But the remuneration isn't that much higher. It's the artistic satisfaction you get and like playing, but you do play the same music all the time. Everybody thinks when you play a book — like Woody for instance didn't care if a drummer could read or not, because he figured if he had an ear in two weeks he could memorize the whole book and there wouldn't be any problem. He'd just tell you when to lay out if you had to lay out, that sort of thing. Benny Goodman never knew if I could read or not I don't think but it didn't make any difference. Because when you were with those bands everybody thinks that well geez you get to play "Four Brothers" every night and you get to play "Don't Be That Way" every night. And when I was with Benny I never played "Sing Sing Sing." We didn't have that in the book. Because he had the book rewritten all in the bebop vein. That was the bebop band that Benny had. And so he had the book rewritten. So we never played "Sing Sing Sing" because that was the old Benny Goodman. He didn't want to do that at that time. But then he started doing it again when he had his bands after that. But I never got to play that

with him and that used to be one of my big numbers in high school man, I used to play that record over and over and over.

MR: Did the people, your audiences, have a harder time dancing to the bebop band of Benny Goodman?

SI: I don't think so, no. The tempos were still medium dance. It's kind of the musical structure rather than the basic rhythm. See the basic rhythm was still a good steady four-four so people were dancing. I don't think Benny would be the type that if he had a drummer that played outside too much he would be comfortable. Because he was a real strong rhythmic player and so he was a marvelous player, geez. Beautiful sense of time and swing. So he knew what he wanted in the band. So esoterically there were people who would say well that's not really bebop, it's not doing this, it's not doing that, it's not doing this. But it was the structure of the music more, the way the arrangements changed the voicings and some of the brass figures and stuff like that.

MR: We were chatting before about later in your studio work, about playing straight eighth notes.

SI: Oh yeah.

MR: Well do you remember when that concept started to change? When the music started to change?

SI: Sure, yeah. It started to change, basically, you know they called Elvis the King, right? But he didn't play much rock & roll, they were all rhythm & blues and Shuffles and stuff like that. The King of rock & roll, but it wasn't a lot of rock & roll. And bands like Harry so-and-so and his—

MR: Harry Comet?

SI: No not Harry Comet, this is the other guy, Bill —

MR: Bill Haley and the Comets.

SI: Bill Haley and the Comets. Yeah. They were like a shuffley kind of thing.

MR: Yeah. It wasn't that much different from swing music.

SI: That's right. Then when I first started doing that and I'll tell you, it was "The Twist," really. You know when people do the old Chubby Checker [scats]. That kind of straight eighth rhythm was the first thing that I had to play because I was doing "Candid Camera." We had a 15-piece band on "Candid Camera." And Art — what's his name?

MR: Alan Funt.

SI: Yeah. He comes in and the leader was a guy named Sid Raymond. And Sid was a very accomplished arranger and conductor. And so he comes in and he says, "hey we have a sequence that we can't use their music, and we've got to have our own music." He says, "do you guys know a 'Twist'?" Everybody said no. A Twist? What the heck is a Twist? "This is a dance everybody does." He says, "I brought a record." So they put the record

on the PA and pumped it into the auditorium to where the band was, right? And you know that's what it was [scats]. If I couldn't have memorized that in five seconds I deserved to be canned. So anyway Alan Funt says to Sid Raymond he says, "Sid, do you think you can write something along those lines?" And he says, "sure." He says, "can you have it ready by the show?" He says, "we'll need about 45 seconds. So he says sure. So he wrote two choruses of blues, and he says, "hey Sonny, do I have to write a part for you?" I said, "no, you don't have to write a part for me, Sid." I says, "you're going to play it like that, right?" He says, "yeah, that's what it's going to be." So he didn't have to write a part. So we played it on the air cold, we didn't even rehearse it, played it on the air cold and I heard it the next week. And we used to do like three in a row or two in a row, I forget which it was. And so I heard it about two weeks later, Jesus, they pumped that in perfect. It sounded exactly like it's supposed to. I said to my wife, "boy, can you imagine having to play like that all the time?" And that's what it came to. They played like that all the time. That's what you hear today. It's all based on that. Straight eighths. And I used to, like I think I told you about that story, I used to listen to the radio going in to a recording date, and listen to what the guys were playing and try to memorize a lot of it and use it when I got to the recording date, because I wasn't playing with those bands and I never listened to that music anyway. And that's how that started with me. That would have been, I was at CBS for almost nine years in the 60s. So that would be in the very early 60s.

MR: Early 60s with Chubby Checker.

SI: Yeah. Early sixties.

MR: So it was like you've seen the writing on the wall?

SI: I didn't. I was stubborn. I was very stubborn. And I said oh it will never happen. Those guys can't play. Listen to that, they can't even play an ending. Every record fades out. They can't even play an ending. None of them can play. But everybody said hey Sonny, you've got to get onto this. So okay. So then it happens that with my good friend Pee Wee Irwin and we were going out to play a jazz gig out in Pennsylvania and I'm driving and Pee Wee and I are chatting. Now this is not to be derogatory to any specific group of people except rock & rollers I guess. So anyway we're talking about the state of the music business. And we're talking about the inroads that rock & rollers made in radio and everything, that's all you hear, because this was in the 70s. And I said, "Jesus, Pee Wee, that's all you hear." And he says, "well you have to admit one thing, Sonny, rock & roll is putting all the amateurs to work." And I never forgot that. And there are guys in rock & roll who can really play, there's no doubt about it. And I like a lot of the drummers I hear in some rock groups. I can't name one right now. But I hate the music they have to play. But I say, "geez, listen to that, that kid can play." Because I know what drums sound like,

I don't care what style it is, if you're going to play Latin if you're playing lousy I'm going to know it. But some of these guys are really good but the music, oh God, terrible. That's only my opinion folks.

MR: You said that you also played early Muppets.

SI: Oh yeah.

MR: Early Muppets.

SI: Yeah, when they first started doing all the shows around New York, you know the T.V. shows. They came on "The Garry Moore Show" several times and that's where I played them.

MR: And you guys would be in the pit?

SI: Yeah we would be in the pit, and they'd have orchestrations, and we just played background music. It was nothing really serious, but it was soft. Because they had to hear the explosions, talking about the way they used to blow each other away when they were new. It's so funny, unbelievable. And they grew up to be such an empire that I was a very, very big admirer of Animal, of course. And actually you know they had Buddy Rich on the show?

MR: The Muppet Show, sure.

SI: Yeah. I have a tape of that.

MR: When he played the room? And he played the stage and stuff.

SI: And walks down and plays all over the stage. And then at the end the dialogue is they bring Animal, "kill, kill, kill, drum battle, drum battle, kill." And Buddy's looking at him and he says, "who's this?" He says, "that's Animal." He says, "he looks like an animal." He says, "if he breaks his chain you'll look like an animal." So anyway it was fantastic. So they get up there and they play back and forth, and Ronnie Verrell was the drummer, an English drummer for the group in the band in London, and he was a marvelous drummer. And so he got going, and he did a good job with the synching. Because they made this frantic drumming of Animal. And then Buddy's looking at him and then he starts up. And then they have these little trades back and forth. And all of a sudden Buddy really starts letting loose. And you can see Animal's eyes, they start to get like this. His eyes, they go like this. And Buddy finishes and he goes [scats] whatever, one of his great flourishes. So Animal takes the snare drum and he goes like this, bamm he throws it, it's over Buddy's head. And that was the end of the show. I love that thing.

MR: Yeah. You have a copy of that you said?

SI: I do, yeah.

MR: That is so great.

SI: It's really a fantastic thing. But working with the Muppets was so much fun. You know we got to talk to those guys, it was only two guys then, that we saw anyway. And they

only had two characters. One of them would get blown away. You remember that. You're dating yourself.

MR: I know, it's okay. Well you've got a great looking wall of photographs over here too. Who are your favorite characters?

SI: There's one of them right behind you, my kid. He's a marvelous drummer. World class.

MR: Yeah. Is he making a living at it?

SI: Ooh. He's world renown. I know that's not — he's a drummer in "The Lion King" and he's also one of the assistant conductors of the show. He's much better than I ever thought of being. He's unreal. He's unreal. He's super. And if I say it, it's not because he's my kid, yes it is. He's my kid and I couldn't be prouder. He really is something. He was a straight kid all his life and he still he. And he's six-six. So if I did anything he'd knock me out. But he's a marvelous player. Absolutely marvelous.

MR: Great.

SI: Play any style, anywhere, anytime. He also travels with Art Garfunkel. Now see now you're going oh yeah, see that's something. To me that's nothing. Yes. I shouldn't say it's nothing, it's a good gig, it pays well. But musically it's terrible.

MR: You think it's terrible, huh?

SI: Oh God. It's so lifeless. Except see Garfunkel has a great group with him, and he features everybody. And the only time the stage gets any energy is when the guys play. Everything else is like [scats]. Very mournful. This is only one man's opinion. Why should I, I shouldn't, erase that.

MR: No. Well you know your opinion, plus I've never seen Garfunkel live. I think of him with Simon.

SI: Well of course. And they hate each other so, it's too bad. It's a terrible thing. And they're going out on tour and they probably won't even talk to each other.

MR: Uh huh. I saw that.

SI: No that's the way some people are. Okay, where are we?

MR: Well I just was wondering, when was your last studio date?

SI: Oh. My last studio date.

MR: And was it a conscious thing, like I'm out of this now?

SI: What happened to me with the studio stuff was that what happened to me with the studio stuff was that I would say it was in the 70s. Mid-70s. I had, we lost our jobs at CBS, NBC, ABC, all the staff orchestras except NBC. NBC still had "The Tonight Show." That's where Ed Shaughnessy was. They still had Johnny Carson and they had a big band as you know.

MR: Sure.

SI: So they were the only ones who were still working. We all lost our jobs because every year the new contract came up and they cut 20 more guys, 20 more guys, 20 more guys. I got finished in 1968. I had 9-3/4 years at CBS. My severance was based on nine years. They wouldn't give me the 3/4 year. Those companies—

MR: The bean counters again.

SI: Oh yeah. See that's what happened to television. Television used to be show business. Now it's situation comedies and car crashes and murders and all that kind of stuff. There's no shows. How dare they call some programs shows? They're programs, they're not shows. A show is with a band and with dancers and singers and you know show people. It used to be run by show people. And then the lawyers and the accountants started to take over and we all lost our jobs and the whole thing changed. Now CBS doesn't do a show, you do a show and sell it to CBS or NBC or whoever wants to buy it. That's the way it works now. And there's no staff musicians, that's gone. Best musician's job left is Broadway.

MR: And even that's shrinking, right?

SI: Well they had to cut down some men, yeah. I started teaching early in my career. I always liked to teach. And I have to say it myself because you don't know but I'm good at it. I have the right disposition and the right patience and all that kind of stuff, and the right expertise. I'm very experienced. And I played with the CBS Symphony. I had a legitimate conductor at CBS who loved the way I played a roll. And he wanted me on everything that he did, because when there were rolls on the snare drum I was the guy. I couldn't believe it. I couldn't believe it. Everybody in the band would say that's like the kiss of death, Sonny, if he likes you. So anyway that's just another phase. But I did all that stuff. But I'm not by any means a concert percussionist. But I was exposed to all that. So my teaching involves a lot of stuff. And I have a lot of guys now, besides my son, I have three other guys working on Broadway who took lessons with me. And it's good for my reputation as far as the teacher goes. But people don't know me as a player anymore. And people really — not too many people heard me as a teacher anymore because it's fading out. Not many people want to study. They don't want to practice. The kids today they want to do a game and watch T.V. or something and play a game and have instant, unless someone is really gifted, they're not going to practice. And I have a couple of good guys, but most of them are just floating along, something to do I guess, I don't know. So when the stuff at CBS stopped in '68 or almost '69, I had already started to build up a teaching practice in New York. So I got into that very heavily. And I got to the point where I was making more money teaching than I ever made playing. So I said this is silly. So I had an answering service called Radio Registry which was the big place in New York. And they used to call me up and say, "Sonny, are you available such-and-

such for an hour?" And I'd say, "for an hour?" I said, "no I'm not available." "Thank you, okay." No an hour would mean I would have to bring my drum case in New York, probably put my car in at least two garages because I have to teach in the morning, then go record in the afternoon then go back and finish my teaching, and it winds up you're not making any money. So that's what happened to me. They finally called me one day about something and I said gee no, I can't do it. She said, "are you working anymore? Do you want to work?" And I said, "to tell you the truth, why don't you skip me for a while. I just want to see how I do with just the teaching." And because we were in an era, there was a recession in the early 70s and everything instead of being two hours was an hour or instead of being four hours was two hours, and everything was getting cut back and all that kind of stuff. And the guys were really scrambling for dates. And there were a lot of dates but they didn't pay as much. And the musicians didn't share in residuals like the singers did. We got paid once around and then after that we got paid three-quarters, and then you got paid a half, then it went down to nothing practically. But the singers got paid big time. The best thing I ever had was once, the Olympics were in Japan, we did a Coca Cola commercial for four hours. That in itself was great. But then they brought the singers in and they did it in every conceivable language you could think so we got paid again for each one. It came to about $6000 or something like that, for four hours. I said boy I'd love to have a job like that all the time. But no go. So that was a long time ago, long time ago. Anyway.

MR: Well you've had an amazing career.

SI: I've had a lot of fun.

MR: And I've enjoyed your opinions.

SI: And I've had a lot of people help me. A friend of yours, Bobby Rosengarden helped me by hiring me at NBC, getting NBC to hire me as his sub so he could go out and make more money recording. Bobby was a great guy, I liked him, I always liked him. And he was a boisterous kind of guy and would run around hollering and screaming and all like that. But he was a much better drummer than people gave him credit for.

MR: Um hum. He's been up to the college a number of times too.

SI: I beg your pardon?

MR: He's been up to the college a number of times.

SI: Oh sure, great.

MR: And you'll be 80 in —

SI: October. That's right.

MR: Congratulations. You look good.

SI: Thank you.

MR: How long have you been married now?

SI: I beg your pardon?

MR: How long have you been married now?

SI: 52 years I think it is. Sure. My little dancing darling.

MR: That's great.

SI: Isn't that great.

MR: Well I want to thank you for your time.

SI: Well it's been my pleasure. I hope I didn't hog everything.

MR: No, no. I got what I was after, let's put it that way.

SI: Did you? Well I'm glad.

MR: I think you will enjoy watching it too.

SI: I'm not one of those cult kind of people, as far as that goes. Nothing mysterious about me I don't think.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot.

SI: Okay. Are we off?

MR: We are now.